

Impact: High Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

Over-explanation signals anxiety or low confidence in your position — it invites challenge by demonstrating uncertainty. Saying what you mean and stopping signals that you believe it, which paradoxically makes others more receptive.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not withholding information — the detail stays available; it just waits to be asked for.
- Not the same as brevity of wording — this is about stopping after the point, however long the point took.
- It is trusting your own point enough to let it stand without scaffolding.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: When they say something, they mean it — there is no anxious padding to wade through.

Principle: Confidence is inferred less from what you say than from what you can leave unsaid.

What you gain

- Points that land at full strength
- Fewer challenges — padding is what invites them
- Conversations that become two-way sooner
- An air of composure under scrutiny
- Answers people can actually remember

Why most people fail at it

- Silence after a point feels like danger, so they fill it.
- They mistake the listener's thinking pause for disagreement.
- Nerves convert into extra sentences.
- Each added justification quietly weakens the previous one.

CORE FORMULA

Make the point -> Stop -> Wait -> Add one sentence only if pressed

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

After making your point, stop before adding another sentence. Sit in the silence. If you feel the pull to add more, resist it for five seconds.

BEST FOR

- Any communication under pressure or scrutiny
- Presenting to senior audiences
- Answering interview or viva-style questions
- Avoiding defensive spirals when challenged

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Point — Make the point once

Say the thing, complete and clear, a single time. One version, chosen in advance — not three drafts of it out loud.

Three drafts: 'It is too risky. I mean, the risk profile is wrong. What I am saying is the downside is too big.'

Once: 'The downside is too big for me to back it.'

2. Stop — Stop and hold

End with a full stop, not a trailing clause. Body language finishes too — settled posture, steady eye contact, no reflexive 'so, yeah'.

Trailing: '...so, yeah, I do not know, that is kind of where I am at, I guess.'

Stopped: 'That is where I stand.'

3. Wait — Let them respond first

Give the silence to the other person. Their reply tells you whether more is wanted — guessing in advance is how monologues start.

Filling: '...and another reason, in case that was not convincing...'

Waiting: (Silence, until they speak.)

4. Add — Add one sentence only if pressed

When they ask for more, give exactly one sentence — then stop again. Detail delivered on request is persuasive; detail delivered pre-emptively is noise.

Flood: 'Well, since you ask, there are six factors...'

Measured: 'The main factor is supplier risk. Want the others?'

FIELD TIP

The silence after your point belongs to them, not you.

The urge to keep talking peaks in the three seconds after you finish — which is exactly when the other person is processing. Fill that gap and you interrupt your own point. Count to five before adding anything.

Situation: You have just given your recommendation and the room is quiet.

Don't: '...and I mean, there are other options too, it is honestly not a big deal either way...'

Do: (Hold the silence. Let them respond first.)

PHRASE BANK

Stopping Phrases · Signals that you are done

- "That is my position."
- "I will leave it there."
- "Happy to expand if that would help."
- "That is the short version."
- "I could say more — I think that is the main point though."
- "Let me stop there and see if you have questions."
- "That is it."

Recovery Stops · Catching yourself mid-over-explain

- "Actually — I am over-explaining. The point is simply: ..."
- "Let me stop there. I was adding too much."
- "I have made the point. Let me leave it."
- "I tend to add too much. The actual point is: ..."
- "Let me cut that down: ..."

Professional Full Stops · Ending cleanly in work settings

- "That is the update. Questions welcome."
- "Nothing further from me unless you want detail."
- "I will pause there — where would you like to go deeper?"
- "That covers the decision. The appendix has the rest."
- "I have one point and I have made it."

Holding the Stop · When scrutiny tempts you to keep talking

- "That is my answer. I am comfortable with it."
- "I have given you my reasoning. I will let it stand."
- "I do not have more to add — not because I am unsure, but because that is the whole point."
- "I would rather leave a clear point than bury it in defence."
- "If there is a specific gap, ask me — otherwise that is my position."

Warm Stops · Brevity that stays kind

- "That is the honest answer, short as it is."
- "I will leave it there — tell me if you want the longer story."
- "Short answer, said with love: no."
- "That is all I meant — nothing hidden behind it."
- "I am keeping it brief because it is simple, not because I do not care."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Three paragraphs where one sentence would have worked
Better: Here is the answer — there are three reasons behind it..
Best: One sentence answer. Then silence. Add detail only if asked.
2. Weak: Restating your point three different ways
Better: I want to make sure I am being clear — ...
Best: State it once, clearly. Trust it landed. Stop.
3. Weak: Adding qualifiers and caveats that dilute the point
Better: There are a few caveats worth noting.
Best: Make the point. Add one caveat only if essential. Stop.

DECISION TREE

If You have made your point and feel the urge to add more

Notice the urge. Pause. Say nothing. See if they respond.

If They look confused after your point

Ask a clarifying question rather than adding more explanation.

"Does that answer the question, or would a different angle help?"

If You catch yourself mid-over-explain

Stop. Name it. Restate the core point.

"Let me cut that down — the actual answer is: ..."

If They press for more detail

Now you can add — but one sentence at a time, then stop again.

"The one detail I would add is..."

If You over-explain because you are nervous

Slow down. The over-explaining is coming from pressure — not from the content needing more.

"I want to answer that directly. The answer is: ..."

SCENARIOS

Answering an interview question

Answer in two sentences. Pause. Let the interviewer respond. — "My experience in X has been Y. That is the core of it."

Presenting a recommendation to a senior person

Give the recommendation. One reason. Stop. — "I recommend X. The main reason is Y."

Being challenged on a decision

Defend once, clearly. Do not add defences on top of defences. — "The reason I made that call was X. I am happy to discuss it."

Explaining yourself after a misunderstanding

Say what you meant once. Resist the urge to keep justifying. — "What I meant was X. That is the full version."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: I was thinking we could maybe try this approach — though obviously there are other ways and I'm not sure it's right and you might know better, but potentially...

Manager: (interrupts) So what are you actually recommending?

With the technique

You: I'd go with Option A. The main reason is cost. Happy to explain more if useful.

Manager: That's clear — let's go with it.

COMMON MISTAKES

Re-answering a question you already answered

Sounds like: '...so as I say, and just to reiterate the point again...'

Better: Trust the first answer. Silence is not a request for a second one.

Stacking justifications

Sounds like: '...and also, and another thing, and to be fair...'

Better: 'That is my main reason. The rest is detail I can give you if useful.'

Diluting with qualifiers

Sounds like: 'I sort of think, maybe, it could possibly be worth considering...'

Better: 'I think we should do it. There is one caveat worth knowing.'

Explaining the explanation

Sounds like: 'What I meant when I said that was... and the reason I phrased it that way...'

Better: 'The point stands as I said it. Which part can I clarify?'

Treating a thinking pause as disagreement

Sounds like: (They pause; you immediately soften your position)

Better: Hold. A pause is processing, not a verdict.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- People ask follow-up questions rather than glazing over.
- You feel more confident after stopping — not more exposed.
- Your points land more clearly.
- The conversation becomes two-way rather than a monologue.

Signs to adjust

- You are stopping too soon and leaving out important context.
- Silence after your point reads as uncertainty.
- You are confusing brevity with unhelpful vagueness.
- You stop explaining but your body language signals that you are not done.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the audience genuinely needs context to evaluate your position — brevity without context can feel dismissive.
- In teaching situations where the explanation is the entire value.
- When legal, medical, or safety contexts require thorough disclosure regardless of length.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I have said the same thing three ways. The first way was right.'

- "I am over-explaining. The point is simply this."
- "Let me stop rescuing that sentence — the answer is X."
- "I have said the same thing three ways. The first way was right."
- "I will stop there. I was adding noise, not signal."
- "You had my answer a minute ago — everything since was nerves."
- "Let me give you the short version I should have led with."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Scrutiny chain

Answer once -> stop -> absorb the pause -> one sentence if pressed

I recommend we pass on this deal.

(Silence.)

The economics only work if renewals double, and I do not believe they will.

Boundary chain

State the no -> stop -> resist the justification pull -> hold

I cannot take this on this quarter.

(Pause — no reasons added.)

I understand it is not what you hoped to hear.

The answer is still no.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC018 — Crisp Brevity

Crisp Brevity shortens the sentences; this discipline stops you adding more of them.

TC029 — Strategic Silence

Strategic Silence is the positive use of the pause you are learning not to fill.

TC012 — Boundary Without Blame

Boundary Without Blame depends on this muscle — a no survives only if it is not buried in justifications.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the urge

In one conversation today, notice every moment when you want to add more after you have made your point. Do not change anything — just notice.

Day 2 — Stop after one sentence

In three exchanges today, stop after one sentence answer and wait.

Day 3 — The pause test

After making your main point, pause for three full seconds before adding anything else.

Day 4 — Catch mid-over-explain

Practise the recovery: 'Let me cut that down — the point is: ...' Use it once today.

Day 5 — Two-sentence limit

Set a self-imposed limit of two sentences for answers to direct questions. Notice the effect.

Day 6 — High-pressure context

Use this in a meeting or presentation where you would normally over-explain.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your communication land better? Did anyone ask for more detail? Did any brevity feel underpowered?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I make my point and stop — without adding another sentence?
- Did I resist the urge to restate the same point three different ways?
- Did I avoid adding qualifiers that diluted the point?
- Did I wait to see if they asked for more before explaining further?
- Did I catch myself over-explaining and self-correct?
- Did I trust that my point had landed rather than re-explaining it?
- Did I keep my energy and tone steady rather than speeding up with more words?